



down from on high—as the movie shows with its dizzying aerial shots. But they feel nothing of the simple sensual pleasures of being human, the joy in the mundane—a division shown cinematically by shooting every scene with the angels in black and white. In an improvised scene, Peter Falk tries on various hats with a costume director, a simple act that

captures the pleasure in everyday experiments with identity that are beyond the angels.

Separations

Wings of Desire is about dualities and separations. Set in a city divided artificially by the Berlin Wall, the spiritual is separated from the sensual, as the heavenly from the mundane, men from women, adults from children. Above all, the movie is about how we are all separated from each other, and a deep sense of loneliness runs through it.

When the angel Damiel begins to fall for the beautiful but lonely trapeze artist Marion (Solveig Dommartin), we sense that they should be together. The process is slow, and in the end Damiel must finally choose whether or not to give up his immortal status in order to experience a physical love for this woman. The viewer is encouraged to believe that this

Physical and metaphysical themes of duality are explored within the movie. Self-reflective and alone, Marion is the earthly equivalent of the angel Damiel.

is the right decision, because Peter Falk, an angel who crossed over long ago, is a living testament of contentment. In crossing over, he has not lost his spiritual side but reunites the spiritual with the material, the child with the adult. He can still sense the presence of the angels, saying “I can’t see you, but I know you’re here.”

Finish vs spontaneity

The parts of Damiel and Cassiel were scripted by Peter Handke, since Wenders felt the angels should speak in elevated language, but Peter Falk’s part is almost entirely improvised. Falk plays a version of himself, an American actor who is in Berlin to make a movie about its Nazi past. The children in the streets call him “Columbo,” after the

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The film is like music or a landscape: It clears a space in my mind, and in that space I can consider questions.

Roger Ebert

Chicago Sun-Times, 1998

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TV detective in the series that had made Falk a famous screen presence.

At one point, Wenders noticed Falk making sketches of extras. He decided to incorporate this into the movie, and had Falk improvise a voice-over, which gains resonance from its roughness: “These people are extras, extra people,” says Falk. “Extras are so patient.” The contrast between the refined, rehearsed script of the angels and the rough spontaneity and mundanity of the scenes with Falk represents the two halves of human life that need to come together.